

THE BALLAD OF READING GAOL

• OSCAR WILDE •

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OF READING GAOL ***

THE BALLAD OF READING GAOL

By Oscar Wilde

In Memoriam

C.T.W.

**Sometime Trooper of the Royal Horse Guards.
Obiit H.M. Prison, Reading, Berkshire,**

July 7th, 1896

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VERSION ONE

I.
He did not wear his scarlet
coat,
For blood and wine are
red,
And blood and wine were
on his hands
When they found him
with the dead,
The poor dead woman
whom he loved,
And murdered in her bed.
He walked amongst the
Trial Men
In a suit of shabby grey;
A cricket cap was on his
head,
And his step seemed light
and gay;
But I never saw a man who
looked
So wistfully at the day.
I never saw a man who
looked
With such a wistful eye
Upon that little tent of blue
Which prisoners call the
sky,

VERSION TWO

I.
He did not wear his scarlet
coat,
For blood and wine are
red,
And blood and wine were
on his hands
When they found him
with the dead,
The poor dead woman
whom he loved,
And murdered in her bed.
He walked amongst the
Trial Men
In a suit of shabby gray;
A cricket cap was on his
head,
And his step seemed light
and gay;
But I never saw a man who
looked
So wistfully at the day.
I never saw a man who
looked
With such a wistful eye
Upon that little tent of blue
Which prisoners call the
sky,

And at every drifting cloud
that went
With sails of silver by.

I walked, with other souls
in pain,
Within another ring,
And was wondering if the
man had done
A great or little thing,
When a voice behind me
whispered low,
"That fellow's got to
swing."

Dear Christ! the very prison
walls
Suddenly seemed to reel,
And the sky above my head
became
Like a casque of scorching
steel;
And, though I was a soul in
pain,
My pain I could not feel.

I only knew what hunted
thought
Quickened his step, and
why
He looked upon the garish
day
With such a wistful eye;
The man had killed the
thing he loved
And so he had to die.

And at every drifting cloud
that went
With sails of silver by.

I walked, with other souls
in pain,
Within another ring,
And was wondering if the
man had done
A great or little thing,
When a voice behind me
whispered low,
"That fellow's got to
swing."

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I only knew what haunted
thought
Quickened his step, and
why
He looked upon the garish
day
With such a wistful eye;
The man had killed the
thing he loved,
And so he had to die.

Yet each man kills the thing
he loves
By each let this be heard,
Some do it with a bitter
look,
Some with a flattering
word,
The coward does it with a
kiss,
The brave man with a
sword!

Some kill their love when
they are young,
And some when they are
old;
Some strangle with the
hands of Lust,
Some with the hands of
Gold:
The kindest use a knife,
because
The dead so soon grow
cold.

Some love too little, some
too long,
Some sell, and others buy;
Some do the deed with
many tears,
And some without a sigh:
For each man kills the thing
he loves,
Yet each man does not die.
He does not die a death of
shame

Yet each man kills the thing
he loves,
By each let this be heard,
Some do it with a bitter
look,
Some with a flattering
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The dead so soon grow
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Some sell, and others buy;
Some do the deed with
many tears,
And some without a sigh:
For each man kills the thing
he loves,
Yet each man does not die.
He does not die a death of
shame

On a day of dark disgrace,
Nor have a noose about his
neck,
Nor a cloth upon his face,
Nor drop feet foremost
through the floor
Into an empty place

He does not sit with silent
men
Who watch him night and
day;
Who watch him when he
tries to weep,
And when he tries to pray;
Who watch him lest
himself should rob
The prison of its prey.

He does not wake at dawn
to see
Dread figures throng his
room,
The shivering Chaplain
robed in white,
The Sheriff stern with
gloom,
And the Governor all in
shiny black,
With the yellow face of
Doom.

He does not rise in piteous
haste
To put on convict-clothes,
While some coarse-
mouthed Doctor gloats, and notes

On a day of dark disgrace,
Nor have a noose about his
neck,
Nor a cloth upon his face,
Nor drop feet foremost
through the floor
Into an empty space.

He does not sit with silent
men
Who watch him night and
day;
Who watch him when he
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And the Governor all in
shiny black,
With the yellow face of
Doom.

He does not rise in piteous
haste
To put on convict-clothes,
While some coarse-
mouthed Doctor gloats, and notes

Each new and nerve-
twitched pose,
Fingering a watch whose
little ticks
Are like horrible hammer-
blows.

He does not know that
sickening thirst
That sands one's throat,
before
The hangman with his
gardener's gloves
Slips through the padded
door,
And binds one with three
leathern thongs,
That the throat may thirst
no more.

He does not bend his head
to hear
The Burial Office read,
Nor, while the terror of his
soul
Tells him he is not dead,
Cross his own coffin, as he
moves
Into the hideous shed.

He does not stare upon the
air
Through a little roof of
glass;
He does not pray with lips
of clay
For his agony to pass;

Each new and nerve-
twitched pose,
Fingering a watch whose
little ticks
Are like horrible hammer-
blows.

He does not feel that
sickening thirst
That sands one's throat,
before
The hangman with his
gardener's gloves
Comes through the padded
door,
And binds one with three
leathern thongs,
That the throat may thirst
no more.

He does not bend his head
to hear
The Burial Office read,
Nor, while the anguish of
his soul
Tells him he is not dead,
Cross his own coffin, as he
moves
Into the hideous shed.

He does not stare upon the
air
Through a little roof of
glass:
He does not pray with lips
of clay
For his agony to pass;

Nor feel upon his
shuddering cheek
The kiss of Caiaphas.

II.

Six weeks our guardsman
walked the yard,
In a suit of shabby grey:
His cricket cap was on his
head,
And his step seemed light
and gay,
But I never saw a man who
looked
So wistfully at the day.

I never saw a man who
looked
With such a wistful eye
Upon that little tent of blue
Which prisoners call the
sky,
And at every wandering
cloud that trailed
Its raveled fleeces by.

He did not wring his hands,
as do
Those witless men who
dare
To try to rear the
changeling Hope
In the cave of black
Despair:
He only looked upon the
sun,

Nor feel upon his
shuddering cheek
The kiss of Caiaphas.

II.

Six weeks the guardsman
walked the yard,
In the suit of shabby gray:
His cricket cap was on his
head,
And his step was light and
gay,
But I never saw a man who
looked
So wistfully at the day.

I never saw a man who
looked
With such a wistful eye
Upon that little tent of blue
Which prisoners call the
sky,
And at every wandering
cloud that trailed
Its ravelled fleeces by.

He did not wring his hands,
as do
Those witless men who
dare
To try to rear the
changeling Hope
In the cave of black
Despair:
He only looked upon the
sun,

air. And drank the morning

air. And drank the morning

He did not wring his hands
nor weep,

He did not wring his hands
nor weep,

Nor did he peek or pine,
But he drank the air as
though it held

Nor did he peek or pine,
But he drank the air as
though it held

Some healthful anodyne;
With open mouth he drank
the sun

Some healthful anodyne;
With open mouth he drank
the sun

As though it had been
wine!

As though it had been
wine!

And I and all the souls in
pain,

And I and all the souls in
pain,

Who tramped the other
ring,

Who tramped the other
ring,

Forgot if we ourselves had
done

Forgot if we ourselves had
done

A great or little thing,
And watched with gaze of
dull amaze

A great or little thing,
And watched with gaze of
dull amaze

The man who had to
swing.

The man who had to
swing.

And strange it was to see
him pass

For strange it was to see
him pass

With a step so light and
gay,

With a step so light and
gay,

And strange it was to see
him look

And strange it was to see
him look

So wistfully at the day,
And strange it was to think
that he

So wistfully at the day,
And strange it was to think
that he

Had such a debt to pay.

Had such a debt to pay.

For oak and elm have
pleasant leaves

That in the spring-time
shoot:

But grim to see is the
gallows-tree,

With its adder-bitten root,
And, green or dry, a man
must die

Before it bears its fruit!

The oak and elm have
pleasant leaves

That in the spring-time
shoot:

But grim to see is the
gallows-tree,

With its alder-bitten root,
And, green or dry, a man
must die

Before it bears its fruit!

The loftiest place is that
seat of grace

For which all worldlings
try:

But who would stand in
hempen band

Upon a scaffold high,
And through a murderer's
collar take

His last look at the sky?

The loftiest place is the seat
of grace

For which all worldlings
try:

But who would stand in
hempen band

Upon a scaffold high,
And through a murderer's
collar take

His last look at the sky?

It is sweet to dance to
violins

When Love and Life are
fair:

To dance to flutes, to dance
to lutes

Is delicate and rare:
But it is not sweet with
nimble feet

To dance upon the air!

It is sweet to dance to
violins

When Love and Life are
fair:

To dance to flutes, to dance
to lutes

Is delicate and rare:
But it is not sweet with
nimble feet

To dance upon the air!

So with curious eyes and
sick surmise

We watched him day by
day,

So with curious eyes and
sick surmise

We watched him day by
day,

And wondered if each one
of us
Would end the self-same
way,
For none can tell to what
red Hell
His sightless soul may
stray.

At last the dead man
walked no more
Amongst the Trial Men,
And I knew that he was
standing up
In the black dock's
dreadful pen,
And that never would I see
his face
In God's sweet world
again.

Like two doomed ships that pass in storm
pass in storm
We had crossed each other's way:
other's way:
But we made no sign, we said no word,
said no word,
We had no word to say;
For we did not meet in the holy night,
holy night,
But in the shameful day.
A prison wall was round us both,
both,
Two outcast men were we:
The world had thrust us from its heart,
from its heart,

And wondered if each one
of us
Would end the self-same
way,
For none can tell to what
red Hell
His sightless soul may
stray.

At last the dead man
walked no more
Amongst the Trial Men,
And I knew that he was
standing up
In the black dock's
dreadful pen,
And that never would I see
his face
For weal or woe again.

Like two doomed ships that
We had crossed each
But we made no sign, we
We had no word to say;
For we did not meet in the
But in the shameful day.

A prison wall was round us
Two outcast men we were:
The world had thrust us
And God from out His

And God from out His care:
care:
And the iron gin that waits for Sin
for Sin
Had caught us in its snare.

III.

In Debtors' Yard the stones are hard,
are hard,
And the dripping wall is high,
high,
So it was there he took the air
air
Beneath the leaden sky,
And by each side a Warder walked,
walked,
For fear the man might die.
die.

Or else he sat with those
Or else he sat with those who watched
who watched
His anguish night and day;
His anguish night and day;
Who watched him when he rose to weep,
rose to weep,
And when he crouched to pray;
And when he crouched to pray;
Who watched him lest himself should rob
himself should rob
Their scaffold of its prey.

The Governor was strong upon
The Governor was strong upon
The Regulations Act:
The Regulations Act:
The Doctor said that Death was but
The Doctor said that Death was but
A scientific fact:
A scientific fact:
And twice a day the

Chaplain called	And twice a day the Chaplain called, And left a little tract.	And left a little tract.
his pipe,	And twice a day he smoked his pipe, And drank his quart of beer:	And twice a day he smoked And drank his quart of
beer:	His soul was resolute, and held No hiding-place for fear; He often said that he was glad	His soul was resolute, and No hiding-place for fear; He often said that he was
held	The hangman's hands near.	The hangman's day was
glad		
were near.		
a thing	But why he said so strange a thing No Warder dared to ask: For he to whom a watcher's doom	But why he said so strange No warder dared to ask: For he to whom a watcher's
doom	Is given as his task, Must set a lock upon his lips,	Is given as his task, Must set a lock upon his
lips,	And make his face a mask.	And make his face a
mask.		
and try	Or else he might be moved, and try To comfort or console: And what should Human Pity do	Or else he might be moved, To comfort or console: And what should Human
Pity do	Pent up in Murderers' Hole?	Pent up in Murderers'
Hole?	What word of grace in such a place	What word of grace in such
a place	Could help a brother's soul?	Could help a brother's

soul?

With slouch and swing
With slouch and swing around the ring
around the ring
We trod the Fool's Parade!
We did not care: we knew we were
The Devil's Own Brigade:
And shaven head and feet of lead
of lead
Make a merry masquerade.
masquerade.

We tore the tarry rope to
shreds
With blunt and bleeding
nails;
We rubbed the doors, and scrubbed the floors,
scrubbed the floors,
And cleaned the shining rails:
rails:
And, rank by rank, we
soaped the plank,
And clattered with the
pails.

We sewed the sacks, we
broke the stones,
We turned the dusty drill:
We banged the tins, and bawled the hymns,
bawled the hymns,
And sweated on the mill:
But in the heart of every man
man
Terror was lying still.
Terror was lying still.
So still it lay that every day
Crawled like a weed-

	Crawled like a weed- clogged wave:	
clogged wave:		And we forgot the bitter lot
	And we forgot the bitter lot	That waits for fool and
	That waits for fool and knave,	
knave,		Till once, as we tramped in
	Till once, as we tramped in from work,	
from work,		We passed an open grave.
	We passed an open grave.	
		With yawning mouth the
	With yawning mouth the horrid hole	
yellow hole		Gaped for a living thing;
	Gaped for a living thing;	The very mud cried out for
	The very mud cried out for blood	
blood		To the thirsty asphalte
	To the thirsty asphalte ring:	
ring:		And we knew that ere one
	And we knew that ere one dawn grew fair	
dawn grew fair		The fellow had to swing.
	Some prisoner had to	
swing.		Right in we went, with soul
		intent
	Right in we went, with soul	On Death and Dread and
intent		Doom:
	On Death and Dread and	The hangman, with his little
Doom:		bag,
	The hangman, with his little	Went shuffling through the
bag,		gloom:
	Went shuffling through the	And I trembled as I groped
gloom		my way
	And each man trembled as	Into my numbered tomb.
he crept		
	Into his numbered tomb.	That night the empty
		corridors
	That night the empty	Were full of forms of Fear,
corridors		And up and down the iron
	Were full of forms of Fear, town	
	And up and down the iron	Stole feet we could not

town		hear,	
	Stole feet we could not		And through the bars that
hear,		hide the stars	
	And through the bars that		White faces seemed to
hide the stars		peer.	
	White faces seemed to		
peer.		He lay as one who lies and	
		dreams	
	He lay as one who lies and		In a pleasant meadow-
dreams		land,	
	In a pleasant meadow-		The watchers watched him
land,		as he slept,	
	The watcher watched him		And could not understand
as he slept,			How one could sleep so
	And could not understand	sweet a sleep	
	How one could sleep so		With a hangman close at
sweet a sleep		hand.	
	With a hangman close at		
hand?		But there is no sleep when	
		men must weep	
	But there is no sleep when		Who never yet have wept:
men must weep			So we- the fool, the fraud,
	Who never yet have wept: the knave-		
	So we—the fool, the fraud,		That endless vigil kept,
the knave—			And through each brain on
	That endless vigil kept,	hands of pain	
	And through each brain on		Another's terror crept.
hands of pain			
	Another's terror crept.		Alas! it is a fearful thing
			To feel another's guilt!
	Alas! it is a fearful thing		For, right within, the sword
	To feel another's guilt!	of Sin	
	For, right within, the sword		Pierced to its poisoned
of Sin		hilt,	
	Pierced to its poisoned		And as molten lead were
hilt,		the tears we shed	
	And as molten lead were		For the blood we had not

the tears we shed spilt.
For the blood we had not
spilt. The warders with their
shoes of felt
The Warders with their Crept by each padlocked
shoes of felt door,
Crept by each padlocked And peeped and saw, with
door, eyes of awe,
And peeped and saw, with Gray figures on the floor,
eyes of awe, And wondered why men
Grey figures on the floor, knelt to pray
And wondered why men Who never prayed before.
knelt to pray
Who never prayed before. All through the night we
knelt and prayed,
All through the night we Mad mourners of a corse!
knelt and prayed, The troubled plumes of
Mad mourners of a midnight shook
corpse! Like the plumes upon a
The troubled plumes of hearse:
midnight were And as bitter wine upon a
The plumes upon a hearse: sponge
And bitter wine upon a Was the savour of
sponge Remorse.
Was the savior of
Remorse. The gray cock crew, the red
cock crew,
The cock crew, the red cock But never came the day:
crew, And crooked shapes of
But never came the day: Terror crouched,
And crooked shape of In the corners where we
Terror crouched, lay:
In the corners where we And each evil sprite that
lay: walks by night
And each evil sprite that Before us seemed to play.
walks by night
Before us seemed to play. They glided past, the glided

	fast,	
glided fast,	They glided past, they	Like travellers through a
	mist:	
mist:	Like travelers through a	They mocked the moon in a
	rigadoon	
rigadoon	They mocked the moon in a	Of delicate turn and twist,
		And with formal pace and
	Of delicate turn and twist, loathsome grace	
loathsome grace	And with formal pace and	The phantoms kept their
	tryst.	
tryst.		With mop and mow, we
	saw them go,	
saw them go,	With mop and mow, we	Slim shadows hand in
	hand:	
hand:	Slim shadows hand in	About, about, in ghostly
	rout	
rout	About, about, in ghostly	They trod a saraband:
		And the damned grotesques
	They trod a saraband: made arabesques,	
made arabesques,	And the damned grotesques	Like the wind upon the
	sand!	
sand!	Like the wind upon the	
		With the pirouettes of
	marionettes,	
marionettes,	With the pirouettes of	They tripped on pointed
	tread:	
tread:	They tripped on pointed	But with flutes of Fear they
		filled the ear,
	But with flutes of Fear they	As their grisly masque
filled the ear,	they led,	
they led,	As their grisly masque	And loud they sang, and
	long they sang,	
loud they sang,	And loud they sang, and	For they sang to wake the
	dead.	
dead.	For they sang to wake the	
		"Oho!" they cried, "the

world is wide,
 "Oho!" they cried, "The world is wide,
 But fettered limbs go lame!
 And once, or twice, to throw the dice
 Is a gentlemanly game,
 But he does not win who plays with Sin
 In the secret House of Shame."
 No things of air these antics were,
 That frolicked with such glee:
 To men whose lives were held in gyves,
 And whose feet might not go free,
 Ah! wounds of Christ! they were living things,
 Most terrible to see.
 Around, around, they waltzed and wound;
 Some wheeled in smirking pairs;
 With the mincing step of a demirep
 Some sidled up the stairs:
 And with subtle sneer, and fawning leer,
 Each helped us at our prayers.
 The morning wind began to moan,

The morning wind began to	But still the night went on:
moan,	Through its giant loom the
But still the night went on:	web of gloom
Through its giant loom the	Crept till each thread was
web of gloom	spun:
Crept till each thread was	And, as we prayed, we
spun:	grew afraid
And, as we prayed, we	Of the Justice of the Sun.
grew afraid	
Of the Justice of the Sun.	The moaning wind went
	wandering round
The moaning wind went	The weeping prison wall:
wandering round	Till like a wheel of turning
The weeping prison-wall: steel	
Till like a wheel of turning-	We felt the minutes crawl:
steel	O moaning wind! what had
We felt the minutes crawl: we done	
O moaning wind! what had	To have such a seneschal?
we done	
To have such a seneschal?	At last I saw the shadowed
	bars,
At last I saw the shadowed	Like a lattice wrought in
bars	lead,
Like a lattice wrought in	Move right across the
lead,	whitewashed wall
Move right across the	That faced my three-plank
whitewashed wall	bed,
That faced my three-plank	And I knew that
bed,	somewhere in the world
And I knew that	God's dreadful dawn was
somewhere in the world	red.
God's dreadful dawn was	
red.	At six o'clock we cleaned
	our cells,
At six o'clock we cleaned	At seven all was still,
our cells,	But the sough and swing of
At seven all was still,	a mighty wing

But the sough and swing of a mighty wing	The prison seemed to fill, For the Lord of Death with icy breath	The prison seemed to fill, For the Lord of Death with Had entered in to kill.
Had entered in to kill.	He did not pass in purple pomp,	He did not pass in purple Nor ride a moon-white
He did not pass in purple pomp,	Nor ride a moon-white steed.	Three yards of cord and a sliding board
Nor ride a moon-white steed.	Three yards of cord and a sliding board	Are all the gallows' need: So with rope of shame the
Are all the gallows' need: So with rope of shame the	Herald came To do the secret deed.	Herald came To do the secret deed.
Herald came To do the secret deed.	We were as men who through a fen	We were as men who Of filthy darkness grope:
We were as men who through a fen	Of filthy darkness grope: prayer, We did not dare to breathe a	We did not dare to breathe a Or to give our anguish
Of filthy darkness grope: prayer, We did not dare to breathe a	prayer, scope:	Or to give our anguish Something was dead in
prayer, scope:	Or give our anguish each of us,	Something was dead in And what was dead was
Or give our anguish each of us,	Something was dead in Hope.	And what was dead was Hope.
Something was dead in each of us,	And what was dead was Hope.	For Man's grim Justice goes its way
And what was dead was Hope.	For Man's grim Justice goes its way,	And will not swerve aside: It slays the weak, it slays
For Man's grim Justice goes its way,	And will not swerve aside: the strong, It slays the weak, it slays	It has a deadly stride: With iron heel it slays the
And will not swerve aside: the strong, It slays the weak, it slays	the strong, It has a deadly stride: strong	With iron heel it slays the The monstrous parricide!
It has a deadly stride: strong With iron heel it slays the	With iron heel it slays the	

strong,
 The monstrous parricide! We waited for the stroke of
 eight:
 We waited for the stroke of Each tongue was thick
 eight:
 with thirst:
 Each tongue was thick For the stroke of eight is
 with thirst:
 the stroke of Fate
 For the stroke of eight is That makes a man
 the stroke of Fate accursed,
 That makes a man And Fate will use a running
 accursed, noose
 And Fate will use a running For the best man and the
 noose worst.
 For the best man and the
 worst.
 do, We had no other thing to
 We had no other thing to Save to wait for the sign
 do, to come:
 Save to wait for the sign So, like things of stone in a
 to come:
 valley lone,
 So, like things of stone in a Quiet we sat and dumb:
 valley lone,
 But each man's heart beat
 Quiet we sat and dumb: thick and quick,
 But each man's heart beat Like a madman on a
 thick and quick drum!
 Like a madman on a
 drum!
 With sudden shock the
 prison-clock
 With sudden shock the Smote on the shivering air,
 prison-clock And from all the gaol rose
 Smote on the shivering air, up a wail
 And from all the gaol rose Of impotent despair,
 up a wail Like the sound the
 Of impotent despair, frightened marshes hear
 Like the sound that From some leper in his
 frightened marshes hear lair.
 From a leper in his lair.

		And as one sees most
	And as one sees most fearful things	
fearful things		In the crystal of a dream,
	In the crystal of a dream,	We saw the greasy hempen
	We saw the greasy hempen rope	
rope		Hooked to the blackened
	Hooked to the blackened beam,	
beam,		And heard the prayer the
	And heard the prayer the hangman's snare	
hangman's snare		Strangled into a scream.
	Strangled into a scream.	
		And all the woe that moved
And all the woe that moved him so		
him so		That he gave that bitter
	That he gave that bitter cry,	
cry,		And the wild regrets, and
	And the wild regrets, and the bloody sweats,	
the bloody sweats,		None knew so well as I:
	None knew so well as I:	For he who lives more lives
	For he who live more lives than one	
than one		More deaths that one must
	More deaths than one die.	
must die.		

IV.

		There is no chapel on the
	There is no chapel on the day	
day		On which they hang a
	On which they hang a man:	
man:		The Chaplain's heart is far
	The Chaplain's heart is far too sick,	
too sick,		Or his face is far too wan,
	Or his face is far to wan,	Or there is that written in
	Or there is that written in his eyes	
his eyes		Which none should look
	Which none should look upon.	
upon.		

		So they kept us close till
So they kept us close till nigh on noon,		
nigh on noon,		And then they rang the
And then they rang the bell,		
bell,		And the warders with their
And the Warders with their jingling keys		
jingling keys		Opened each listening
Opened each listening cell,		
cell,		And down the iron stair we
And down the iron stair we tramped,		
tramped,		Each from his separate
Each from his separate Hell.		
Hell.		
		Out into God's sweet air we
Out into God's sweet air we went,		
went,		But not in wonted way,
But not in wonted way,		For this man's face was
For this man's face was white with fear,		
white with fear,		And that man's face was
And that man's face was gray,		
grey,		And I never saw sad men
And I never saw sad men who looked		
who looked		So wistfully at the day.
So wistfully at the day.		
		I never saw sad men who
I never saw sad men who looked		
looked		With such a wistful eye
With such a wistful eye		Upon that little tent of blue
Upon that little tent of blue		We prisoners called the
We prisoners called the sky,		
sky,		And at every happy cloud
And at every careless cloud that passed		
that passed		In such strange freedom
In happy freedom by.	by.	
But there were those		But there were those
amongst us all	amongst us all	

Who walked with downcast head, And knew that, had each got his due, They should have died instead: He had but killed a thing that lived Whilst they had killed the dead.	Who walked with downcast head, And knew that, had each got his due, They should have died instead: He had but killed a thing that lived, Whilst they had killed the dead.
---	--

For he who sins a second time Wakes a dead soul to pain, And draws it from its spotted shroud, And makes it bleed again, And makes it bleed great gouts of blood And makes it bleed in vain!	For he who sins a second time Wakes a dead soul to pain, And draws it from its spotted shroud And makes it bleed again, And makes it bleed great gouts of blood, And makes it bleed in vain!
---	---

Like ape or clown, in monstrous garb With crooked arrows starred, Silently we went round and round The slippery asphalte yard; Silently we went round and round, And no man spoke a word.	Like ape or clown, in monstrous garb With crooked arrows starred, Silently we went round and round The slippery asphalte yard; Silently we went round and round, And no man spoke a word.
--	--

Silently we went round and round,	Silently we went round and round,
--------------------------------------	--------------------------------------

mind And through each hollow
 The memory of dreadful
things things
 Rushed like a dreadful
wind, wind,
 An Horror stalked before
each man, each man,
 And terror crept behind.

 The Warders strutted up
and down, down,
 And kept their herd of
brutes, brutes,
 Their uniforms were spick
and span, and span,
 And they wore their
Sunday suits, Sunday suits,
 But we knew the work they
had been at had been at,
 By the quicklime on their
boots. boots.

 For where a grave had
opened wide, opened wide,
 There was no grave at all:
 Only a stretch of mud and
sand sand
 By the hideous prison-
wall, wall,
 And a little heap of burning
lime, lime,
 That the man should have
his pall. his pall.

 For he has a pall, this
wretched man,

And through each hollow
mind mind
 The Memory of dreadful
things things
 Rushed like a dreadful
wind, wind,
 And Horror stalked before
each man, each man,
 And Terror crept behind.

The warders strutted up and
down, down,
 And watched their herd of
brutes, brutes,
 Their uniforms were spick
and span, and span,
 And they wore their
Sunday suits, Sunday suits,
 But we knew the work they
had been at, had been at,
 By the quicklime on their
boots. boots.

For where a grave had
opened wide, opened wide,
 There was no grave at all:
 Only a stretch of mud and
sand sand
 By the hideous prison-
wall, wall,
 And a little heap of burning
lime, lime,
 That the man should have
his pall. his pall.

For he has a pall, this
wretched man,

claim: Such as few men can
 Deep down below a prison-
yard,
 Naked for greater shame,
He lies, with fetters on each
foot,
 Wrapt in a sheet of flame!

 And all the while the
burning lime
 Eats flesh and bone away,
 It eats the brittle bone by
night,
 And the soft flesh by the
day,
 It eats the flesh and bones turns,
by turns,
 But it eats the heart away.

 For three long years they will not sow
will not sow
 Or root or seedling there:
 For three long years the unblessed spot
unblessed spot
 Will sterile be and bare,
 And look upon the wondering sky
wondering sky
 With unreproachful stare.

 They think a murderer's heart would taint
heart would taint
 Each simple seed they sow.
sow.
 It is not true! God's kindly earth
earth
 Is kindlier than men know,

 Such as few men can
claim:
 Deep down below a prison-
yard,
 Naked, for greater shame,
He lies, with fetters on each
foot,
 Wrapt in a sheet of flame!

 And all the while the
burning lime
 Eats flesh and bone away,
 It eats the brittle bones by
night,
 And the soft flesh by day,
It eats the flesh and bone by
 But it eats the heart away.

 For three long years they
Or root or seedling there:
 For three long years the
Will sterile be and bare,
 And look upon the
With unreproachful stare.

 They think a murderer's
Each simple seed they
It is not true! God's kindly
Is kindlier than men know,
And the red rose would but

And the red rose would but glow more red,
blow more red,

The white rose whiter
blow.

The white rose whiter blow.
blow.

Out of his mouth a red, red rose!
 Out of his heart a white!
 For who can say by what strange way,
 Christ brings his will to light,
 Since the barren staff the pilgrim bore
 Bloomed in the great Pope's sight?
 Out of his mouth a red, red
 rose!
 Out of his heart a white!
 For who can say by what
 strange way,
 Christ brings His will to
 light,
 Since the barren staff the
 pilgrim bore
 Bloomed in the great
 Pope's sight?

	But neither milk-white rose	nor red
But neither milk-white rose nor red		May bloom in prison air;
	May bloom in prison air;	The shard, the pebble, and
	The shard, the pebble, and the flint,	
the flint,		Are what they give us
	Are what they give us there:	
there:		For flowers have been
	For flowers have been known to heal	
known to heal		A common man's despair.
	A common man's despair.	

	So never will wine-red rose
So never will wine-red rose or white,	
or white,	Petal by petal, fall
Petal by petal, fall	On that stretch of mud and
On that stretch of mud and sand that lies	
sand that lies	By the hideous prison-
By the hideous prison- wall,	
wall,	To tell the men who tramp
To tell the men who tramp the yard	
the yard	That God's Son died for

canvas clothes,
And gave him to the flies;
They mocked the swollen
purple throat
And the stark and staring
eyes:
And with laughter loud
they heaped the shroud
In which the convict lies.

The Chaplain would not
kneel to pray
By his dishonored grave:
Nor mark it with that
blessed Cross
That Christ for sinners
gave,
Because the man was one of those
Whom Christ came down to save.

Yet all is well; he has but
passed
To Life's appointed bourne:
And alien tears will fill for him
Pity's long-broken urn,
For his mourner will be men,
outcast men,
And outcasts always mourn.

V.

I know not whether Laws be right,

V.

I know not whether Laws

be right,		Or whether Laws be
	Or whether Laws be wrong;	
wrong;		All that we know who lie in
	All that we know who lie in gaol	
gaol		Is that the wall is strong;
	Is that the wall is strong;	And that each day is like a
	And that each day is like a year,	
year,		A year whose days are
	A year whose days are long.	
long.		
	But this I know, that every Law	But this I know, that every
Law		That men have made for
	That men have made for Man,	
Man,		Since first Man took His
	Since first Man took his brother's life,	
brother's life,		And the sad world began,
	And the sad world began,	But straws the wheat and
	But straws the wheat and saves the chaff	
saves the chaff		With a most evil fan.
	With a most evil fan.	
		This too I know- and wise
	This too I know—and wise it were	
it were		If each could know the
	If each could know the same-	
same—		That every prison that men
	That every prison that men build	
build		Is built with bricks of
	Is built with bricks of shame,	
shame,		And bound with bars lest
	And bound with bars lest Christ should see	
Christ should see		How men their brothers
	How men their brothers maim.	
maim.		
		With bars they blur the
	With bars they blur the gracious moon,	
gracious moon,		And blind the goodly sun:

	And blind the goodly sun:	And they do well to hide
	And they do well to hide their Hell,	
their Hell,	For in it things are done	For in it things are done
	That Son of God nor son of Man	That Son of God nor son of
Man	Ever should look upon!	Ever should look upon!
		The vilest deeds like poison
	The vilest deeds like poison weeds	
weeds	Bloom well in prison-air:	Bloom well in prison-air:
	It is only what is good in Man	It is only what is good in
Man		That wastes and withers
	That wastes and withers there:	
there:	Pale Anguish keeps the heavy gate,	Pale Anguish keeps the
heavy gate,	And the Warder is Despair	And the warder is Despair.
		For they starve the little
	For they starve the little frightened child	
frightened child	Till it weeps both night and day:	Till it weeps both night
and day:	And they scourge the weak,	And they scourge the weak,
	And they scourge the weak, and flog the fool,	
and flog the fool,	And gibe the old and grey,	And gibe the old and gray,
	And some grow mad, and all grow bad,	And some grow mad, and
all grow bad,	And none a word may say.	And none a word may say.
		Each narrow cell in which
	Each narrow cell in which we dwell	
we dwell	Is a foul and dark latrine,	Is a foul and dark latrine,
	And the fetid breath of living Death	And the fetid breath of
living Death	Chokes up each grated screen,	Chokes up each grated
screen,		And all, but Lust, is turned

to dust	And all, but Lust, is turned to dust	In Humanity's machine.
	In Humanity's machine.	
	The brackish water that we drink	The brackish water that we
drink	Creeps with a loathsome slime,	Creeps with a loathsome
slime,	And the bitter bread they weigh in scales	And the bitter bread they
weigh in scales	Is full of chalk and lime,	Is full of chalk and lime,
	And Sleep will not lie down, but walks	And Sleep will not lie
down, but walks	Wild-eyed and cries to Time.	Wild-eyed, and cries to
Time.		
	But though lean Hunger and green Thirst	But though lean Hunger
and green Thirst	Like asp with adder fight,	Like asp with adder fight,
	We have little care of prison fare,	We have little care of
prison fare,	For what chills and kills outright	For what chills and kills
outright	Is that every stone one lifts by day	Is that every stone one lifts
by day	Becomes one's heart by night.	Becomes one's heart by
night.		
	With midnight always in one's heart,	With midnight always in
one's heart,	And twilight in one's cell,	And twilight in one's cell,
	We turn the crank, or tear the rope,	We turn the crank, or tear
the rope,	Each in his separate Hell,	Each in his separate Hell,
	And the silence is more awful far	And the silence is more
awful far	Than the sound of a brazen bell.	Than the sound of a

brazen bell.

	And never a human voice
And never a human voice comes near	
comes near	To speak a gentle word:
To speak a gentle word:	And the eye that watches
And the eye that watches through the door	
through the door	Is pitiless and hard:
Is pitiless and hard:	And by all forgot, we rot
And by all forgot, we rot and rot,	
and rot,	With soul and body
With soul and body marred.	
marred.	

	And thus we rust Life's iron
And thus we rust Life's iron chain	
chain	Degraded and alone:
Degraded and alone:	And some men curse, and
And some men curse, and some men weep,	
some men weep,	And some men make no
And some men make no moan:	
moan:	But God's eternal Laws are
But God's eternal Laws are kind	
kind	And break the heart of
And break the heart of stone.	
stone.	

	And every human heart that
And every human heart that breaks,	
breaks,	In prison-cell or yard,
In prison-cell or yard,	Is as that broken box that
Is as that broken box that gave	
gave	Its treasure to the Lord,
Its treasure to the Lord,	And filled the unclean
And filled the unclean leper's house	
leper's house	With the scent of costliest
With the scent of costliest nard.	
nard.	

Ah! happy they whose
Ah! happy day they whose hearts can break

hearts can break	And peace of pardon win!	And peace of pardon win!
And peace of pardon win!	How else may man make	How else may man make
How else may man make straight his plan	And cleanse his soul from	And cleanse his soul from
straight his plan	Sin?	Sin?
And cleanse his soul from Sin?	How else but through a	How else but through a
Sin?	broken heart	broken heart
How else but through a broken heart	May Lord Christ enter in?	May Lord Christ enter in?
broken heart	And he of the swollen	And he of the swollen
May Lord Christ enter in?	purple throat,	purple throat,
	And the stark and staring	And the stark and staring
And he of the swollen purple throat,	eyes,	eyes,
And the stark and staring eyes,	Waits for the holy hands	Waits for the holy hands
eyes,	that took	that took
Waits for the holy hands that took	The Thief to Paradise;	The Thief to Paradise;
that took	And a broken and a contrite	And a broken and a contrite
The Thief to Paradise;	heart	heart
And a broken and a contrite heart	The Lord will not despise.	The Lord will not despise.
heart	The man in red who reads	The man in red who reads
The Lord will not despise.	Gave him three weeks of	Gave him three weeks of
The man in red who reads the Law	Three little weeks in which	Three little weeks in which
the Law	His soul of his soul's	His soul of his soul's
Gave him three weeks of life,	And cleanse from every	And cleanse from every
life,	blot of blood	blot of blood
Three little weeks in which to heal	The hand that held the	The hand that held the
to heal	knife.	knife.
His soul of his soul's strife,		
strife,	And with tears of blood he	And with tears of blood he
And cleanse from every blot of blood	cleansed the hand,	cleansed the hand,
blot of blood	The hand that held the	The hand that held the
The hand that held the knife.		
knife.		
	And with tears of blood he	And with tears of blood he
And with tears of blood he cleansed the hand,	The hand that held the	The hand that held the
cleansed the hand,		
The hand that held the steel:		

steel: For only blood can wipe
For only blood can wipe out blood,
out blood, And only tears can heal:
And only tears can heal: And the crimson stain that
And the crimson stain that was of Cain
was of Cain Became Christ's snow-
Became Christ's snow- white seal.
white seal.

VI.

VI.
In Reading gaol by Reading
town
In Reading gaol by Reading town
There is a pit of shame,
And in it lies a wretched man
man
Eaten by teeth of flame,
In a burning winding-sheet
he lies, In burning winding-sheet he lies,
And his grave has got no name.
name.

And there, till Christ call
And there, till Christ call forth the dead,
forth the dead, In silence let him lie:
In silence let him lie: No need to waste the
No need to waste the foolish tear,
foolish tear, Or heave the windy sigh:
Or heave the windy sigh: The man had killed the
The man had killed the thing he loved,
thing he loved, And so he had to die.
And so he had to die.

And all men kill the thing
And all men kill the thing they love,
they love, By all let this be heard,
By all let this be heard, Some do it with a bitter
Some do it with a bitter look,
look, Some with a flattering

	Some with a flattering word,	
word,		The coward does it with a
	The coward does it with a kiss,	
kiss,		The brave man with a
	The brave man with a sword!	
sword!		

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